Lesson 45 material: The Language of Argument

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

5.10: Language Toolkit

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Language for Concession/Counterargument

When you write a concession or counterargument, you need to clearly show whose perspective you are talking about, and signal to your reader when you are switching back and forth from one perspective to another. Table 5.10.1 provides some useful language for these tasks. Note: this assumes you are writing an entire paragraph addressing another perspective, but you can also use this concept and this language in smaller bits.

Table 5.10.1: Language for Concession/Counterargument

Part of the paragraph	**What to write**	**Possible language**							
Part 1	**Topic sentence/point** that names the other perspective:	1+ sentences	**Start with connecting words and, if logical, reporting words to make clear that you are switching to a perspective that is not your own opinion.**	State	an opposite idea	a question about, concern about, or problem with your idea	an exception to your idea	the inherency (if your idea/plan is so great, why isn't everyone already doing it?)	If this is not your first concession/counterargu paragraph, make that cl with connecting words t add ideas (Another. . ., ..., In addition, . . .)
Part 2	**Evidence/specific information**	that supports the other perspective:	2+ sentences	**Give evidence/specifics** of this other perspective:	why do they think this?	how many think this?	quote/paraphrase from someone who thinks this	give specific details about the point (e.g. if the problem is that your idea is expensive, how much money will it cost?)	**and explain** their poin view, being careful to so fair and balanced.
Part 3	**Response** that defends and explains your position:	2+ sentences	**Start with connecting words and, if logical, reporting words to make clear that we are now back to your own position,** explain why the other perspective	is not true	is biased	is using a logical fallacy	is true but not that important, worth the cost, etc.	is true, but the evidence actually proves your side	or otherwise respond in way that shows your pos is still stronger.

Naming and Refuting Logical Fallacies

Table 5.10.2 provides language for naming, explaining, and refuting common logical fallacies.

Table 5.10.2 Language for Responding to Logical Fallacies

Part of your sentence	suggested language patterns								
Sentence 1:	source of the fallacy	The author/researchers etc.	The advertisers	Marketers of X	Some people	Those who agree with X	Those who disagree with X	People who think X	Proponer of X
special reporting verb phrase	imply(ies) that	seem(s) to imply that	seem(s) to think that	would have us believe that	want(s) us to believe that	wrongly suppose(s) that	claim(s) that	try(ies) to show that	want(s) t that
paraphrase/summary of their argument	X caused Y.	Y because X.	because X, Y.	X, therefore Y.	based on X, Y.	X proves Y.	we must choose between X and Y.	we should/shouldn't X, because Y might result.	X will lea
Sentence 2:	transition to your rebuttal	Clearly,	However,	When we examine his/her/their logic, however,	The problem with this argument is that . . .	On closer inspection,			
rename the source (opponent)	he/she/they	the author/politician/advertiser etc.							
special verb	is/are using	is/are engaging in	falls into the trap of	is/are trying to trick us with					
name the fallacy/error	the X fallacy	a manipulative appeal to Y	faulty/flawed reasoning/logic						
Sentence 3:	explain the error	Just because X doesn't mean Y.	There might be another factor that caused Y.	It might be true that X means Y, but this doesn't prove it.	There is probably another explanation: Y.	X might indeed cause Y, but this evidence doesn't prove it because...	There is no solid proof that if X, Y.	We need to show/prove/see more evidence that/substantiate the claim that Y.	In fact, th a better v

Argumentation terms

These are key academic words that are helpful for explaining the structure of arguments and pointing out flaws in reasoning. Keywords are in **bold**; examples are *italicized*.

Disagreement terms

Table 5.10.3 contains words we use to name or describe an area of disagreement, or which position someone is taking in the disagreement:

Table 5.10.3 Argumentation Terms for Disagreement

Term and part of speech	Definition(s) and derivative forms	Examples			
perspective	(count noun)	position, point of view, or attitude toward something; the way someone thinks about an idea, problem, or controversy. Sometimes we use this word to indicate that the person's experience or identity helps or causes them to see the situation in a certain way.	*The local residents were able to provide a historical **perspective** that the visitors were not aware of.*	*My grandmother has lived long enough to have a broader **perspective**.*	*The editorial in the Los Angeles Times offered a very different **perspective** on the new policy.*

controversial	(adj.)	causing a debate of strong opinions on different sides; **controversy** (count or non-count noun)	*The school board will discuss the **controversial** issue of whether to allow staff without vaccines to keep working.*	*The subway strike was **controversial**; most riders supported the workers, but some were angry that they couldn't get to their own jobs.*	*Wilde was a **controversial** author; many loved him, but many hated him.*		
proponent	(count noun)	someone who supports an idea, plan, or another person; advocate [antonym of opponent]; **propose** (transitive verb)	***Proponents** of the boycott argue that it will put pressure on the company to improve working conditions.*	*Surprisingly, the worker's rights activist was not a **proponent** of the boycott.*	*The engineers **proposed** a different solution to the polluted runoff from the fabric dyeing station.*		
opponent	(count noun)	someone who is against an idea, plan, or another person, and is trying to stop them or win against them [antonym of proponent]; **oppose** (transitive verb); **opposition** (non-count noun)	***Opponents** of bilingual education may argue that it doesn't work, but they're mistaken.*	*During the primary elections, McCain was Bush's leading **opponent**.*	*Smith is a bitter/vocal/outspoken **opponent** of gun control.*	*Several members of the city council **opposed** the new zoning regulations.*	*The garment workers union faced considerable **opposition** from the company when they began to organize.*

Logical relationship terms

Table 5.10.4 contains words we use to name how two or more events or facts are related to each other:

Table 5.10.4 Argumentation Terms for Logical Relationships

Term and part of speech	Definition(s) and derivative forms	Examples					
cause	(usually count but sometimes non-count noun)	an action or event that is the reason for another action or event; **cause** (transitive verb); **causal** (adj.); **causation** (non-count noun)	We use **causation** to emphasize that one event or situation really did cause another event in a way we can prove.-	*One **cause** of the rise of fast fashion was the increasing popularity of social media.*	*Coverage of the horrible factory fire **caused** many to pay attention to working conditions in the garment industry for the first time.*	*There were too many complicated factors for scientists to easily prove a **causal** relationship between the specific chemicals polluting the water and rising cancer rates. It's possible that air pollution, poor nutrition, smoking, or something else was **causing** the increase in cases.*	*Researchers noticed that patients who took the medication had increased rates of arthritis, but there wasn't enough evidence to show **causation**.*
consistent	(adj.)	matching, making a predictable pattern, making sense together; **inconsistent** (adj.); **consistency/inconsistency** (count or non-count noun); **consistently/inconsistently** (adv.)	*The workers' union asked the factory owners to install ventilation systems **consistent** with the safety plan in the contract.*	*The damage to the building is **consistent** with the theory that an electrical problem caused the fire.*	*Sales have been **inconsistent**; sometimes higher than expected, sometimes lower.*	*The investigators noticed **inconsistencies** in the two suspects' stories; for example, one said they were traveling to a convention, while the other said they were vacationing.*	*Studies **consistently** reported better outcomes for girls with more years of education.*
correlation	(count or non-count noun)	two events, actions, or amounts being connected or happening at the same time; **correlated** (adj.)	*The study found a strong **correlation** between urban poverty and poor health.*	*There is a direct **correlation** between levels of union membership and equal distribution of wealth in a country.*	*Social media use is **correlated** with low self-esteem.*	*At first, they thought drinking coffee caused lung cancer, but then they realized coffee drinking was **correlated** with cigarette smoking, which was the actual cause.*	

factor	(count noun)	one part of a cause with more than one part; one event or condition that, along with other events or conditions, leads to an effect	*Two **factors** that influence the price of clothing are labor cost and materials cost.*	*The researchers forgot to consider the age of the subjects, which was an important **factor** in how well they responded to the treatment.*	*The study designers needed to make sure there were no confounding **factors**, so they made sure the subjects were evenly distributed between the groups in every way.*
random	(adj.)	not according to any pattern or set of rules; unpredictable	*Whether you get heads or tails when flipping a coin is purely **random**.*	*The polling organization conducted a **random** sample of five hundred American teenagers.*	

Reasoning terms

Table 5.10.5 contains words we use to name how a person made a decision or why they think something:

Table 5.10.5 Argumentation Terms for Reasoning

Term and part of speech	Definition(s) and derivative forms	Examples			
arbitrary	(adj.)	chosen without a particular reason or pattern; similar to **random**, but arbitrary is more about a person making a decision without following a consistent or fair rule, so it sometimes has a connotation of "unfair" when used to describe actions of people in power; **arbitrarily** (adv.)	*Was there a system for choosing which students were called on? No, it was the teacher's **arbitrary** decision.*	*International law protects people from **arbitrary** imprisonment; a leader cannot just throw someone they don't like in jail.*	*The factory owner gave an **arbitrarily** chosen number of workers the day off, but wouldn't explain his decision.*
assumption	(count noun)	a guess; an idea that someone believes even though they may not have all the information or evidence that it is true; **assume** (transitive verb)	*The professor made the **assumption** that the student didn't care about the class, but actually, the student was just tired from his night shift.*	*Based on the **assumption** that infection rates might increase, the company bought stock in masks and hand sanitizer.*	*The factory owners correctly **assumed** that customers would not boycott the brand even if they kept the workers from unionizing.*
findings	(count noun, usually plural)	the information or answers someone finds from doing research	*Nobody was surprised by the **findings** of a recent study that indicated people living close to factories have increased rates of asthma.*	*We expected that the new medicine would work well, but unfortunately, the **findings** of the clinical trial contradicted our prediction.*	

Evaluation terms

Table 5.10.6 contains words we use to evaluate someone's decision or explain whether we should believe them:

Table 5.10.6 Argumentation Terms for Evaluation

Term and part of speech	Definition(s) and derivative forms	Examples			
contradiction	(count noun)	two statements or actions by the same person that go against each other or can't both be true; **contradict** (transitive verb); **contradictory** (adj.)	*She pointed out a **contradiction** between the government's ideas and its actual policy*	*The writer **contradicts** his own idea when he says that boycotts are the only solution and also that boycotts are a terrible plan.*	*The safety plan had **contradictory** rules: it stated that workers were required to stand six feet apart, but also that there could be up to 40 people in a small room.*
credibility	(non-count noun)	deserving to be believed and trusted; **credible** (adj.)	*The politician ran ads listing her past accomplishments in order to establish her **credibility** as a leader.*	*After they were wrong about a major election, the polling organization lost **credibility** with the public.*	*The report suggesting the chemical was safe came from a company manufacturing that same chemical, so I don't think that's a **credible** source.*

valid	(adj.)	reasonable, sensible, acceptable, logical; ***validity*** (non-count noun)	*The economist made a **valid** point that a livable minimum wage is a different amount in different countries.*	*She raised a perfectly **valid** question: do we really need new clothing for every occasion?*	*His argument lacks **validity**; it's true that we all need clothing, but that doesn't mean we all need a new outfit every single time we go out.*

Argumentation terms review

Let's try out using these terms.

Try this!

Read each sentence. In each sentence, a word has been replaced by the letter "X". Decide which of the three choices at the end would be the best replacement for "X". Use the meaning and the grammar pattern to help you decide.

1. The union was negotiating for a pay raise X with the cost of living for the region. (opponent/consistent/random)
2. Opponents of a boycott raised a X point, that the boycott might actually hurt the workers it was meant to help. (valid/findings/factor)
3. After the scientists recorded the amount of pesticides in the runoff from the cotton fields, they presented their X at an environmental health conference. (credibility/random/findings)
4. The decision to strike was X ; some of the workers were convinced it was the only path forward, but others were afraid to lose their jobs or even face retaliation. (contradiction/controversial/correlation)
5. The lack of economic opportunities in rural areas is one X driving many women to move to cities in search of factory jobs. (factor/arbitrary/assume)
6. Research on decision-making shows that when we feel a X between our behavior and our values, such as when we are shopping for unethically-made products, we feel very uncomfortable, and usually change our values to match our behavior. (consistent/credibility/contradiction)

For suggested answers, see 5.12: Answer Key - Analyzing Arguments Answer Key

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5.11: Takeaways

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Summary

In this chapter we

- identified the three main rhetorical appeals: ethos, pathos, and logos
- analyzed arguments in readings to find and evaluate ethos, pathos, and logos
- analyzed the structure of logical syllogisms
- practiced finding, naming, explaining, and refuting logical fallacies
- analyzed concession and counterargument in readings and learned language strategies for comparing multiple perspectives
- identified and practiced language for hedging

Questions for reflection

- How can you use strategies for analyzing arguments outside of school?
- What concepts in this chapter did you already know intuitively from your own life experience?
- What concepts in this chapter did you already know from studying math and science?
- How do you think different languages or cultures approach argumentation differently?
- Find an essay, article, advertisement, or political speech. What kind of persuasive appeals does the writer use? Are they effective?
- Look back at 5.2: Sample Student Research Essay - Fast Fashion and the other sample essays in this book. What are the writers' major and minor premises? Can you find examples of ethos, pathos, and logos? Concession and counterargument? Hedging language? What other concessions or counterarguments might you address on the same topic?

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